UPFRONT

ECOWATCH: DRYING LAKES OF J&K PG 9

GRAPHIC: GEN-Z BORROWERS PG 10



▶ FCRA BILL

CHURCH VERSUS STATE

Amid protests by Christian groups and political backlash in the poll season, the Centre has paused FCRA amendments to tighten foreign funding rules, but concerns remain over its return

By M.G. ARUN and JEEMON JACOB

CAUGHT IN POLL-SEASON ARITHMETIC AMID OPPOSITION AND RELIGIOUS PUSHBACK, the government has shelved the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25. However, concerns among Christian minorities refuse to die down, with fears that the bill could return when Parliament reconvenes.

The proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, which regulates the acceptance and utilisation of foreign contributions by individuals, associations and companies, stirred the proverbial hornet's nest, with Christian leaders arguing that it undermines federalism and gives the Centre sweeping powers over community-run institutions. "This is a straightforward loot of Christian institutions and their properties," Archbishop Joseph D'Souza, president of the All India Christian Council, told the media. "FCRA authorities have become an extra-constitutional apparatus in India...this has become one of the most non-transparent government bodies in India."

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**